Wednesday, 18 March 2026 (29 Adar 5786) — Preparing and Leading the פסח Seder (Guest Shiur, Rabbi Yechiel Spero)

Content-based review · reviewer read the transcripts, summary, and finished write-up · 8 November 2026

1.The Shiur in One Paragraph

A guest shiur by Rabbi Yechiel Spero at Rabbi Ephrati's shul, delivered in advance of *Pesach*: a practical, prop-in-hand guide for the parent who will lead the *seder*. It opens with the idea that the whole year is contained in the *seder* (source supplied from the audience: the *Imrei Chaim*), the goal of "technical success," and the personal *haggadah* (front page: "Relax. You are running the seder. It's not your show"). It then moves through involving children by ownership (the laminator, the sticky notes limited to five *divrei Torah*, the "ADD haggadah" that is not the goal), the aim that every child leave knowing that Hashem loves him (the FAITH sign and the seder shekel), the older children (pool noodle, a once-a-year bribe), the pre-measured bags of *matzah* and *maror*, the tips of opening all the wine beforehand and keeping whole and broken *matzah* apart, and "do not set the table." The reward system follows (prizes, Keep Focus cards, the scavenger hunt, the hidden-value seder shekalim, the two bowls), with questions valued over answers (deliberate mistakes, written stories, prepared questions). The one *dvar Torah* is the Targum on *v'higadta* ("show" your child) and the *Sfas Emes* (the other transcript: *Sifsei Chaim*) on why the verse adds *mibeis avadim* (paint the picture), illustrated by the speaker's own talk at his brother-in-law's *sheloshim*. The remainder is the catalogue of props (house, plagues, Chad Gadya, bricks, the chase after

Dayenu and *Hodu* at the instruments, the item that stands for slavery or freedom, the speaker's mother), a caution about posters, and a close on engagement over entertainment.

2.Overall Fidelity

The write-up follows the content of the shiur closely, and, unlike several earlier weeks, the practical material (the bags, the shekalim arithmetic, the plague props) is reproduced accurately. Three sources were read: the bilingual Plaud-style transcript (AUDIO-2026-03-18-23-11-46.txt; clearest, it glosses each Hebrew word and is authoritative on every point below), the Sofer-style transcript ("Speaker 1"; garbled in places, e.g. "Ehi Shomda," "tzachadash ba'achav," "awesomemath.com"), and the AI summary. **No Sofer .docx exists for this date**, so the Sofer .txt was treated as secondary to the bilingual file. **The pattern is the same as in previous weeks: the write-up inherited its misstatements from the summary.** Its errors are of four kinds: a source, a title and several details that the summary got wrong (the Chida, the inscription on the staff, *shelo lishmah*, *Hodu*); an anecdote told about the wrong person; claims in the lead and the apparatus that the recording does not support; and a group of citations added in the apparatus that do not hold up when checked. Items fixed in the final-MM HTML in this pass are marked.

3.Content Flags — Misstatements and Overclaims

> **Flag 1 — The mother at the seder is the speaker's own mother.** The write-up (Section XVIII): "this exercise convinced a mother who had insisted on leaving the seder at 10:00 PM to participate fully — she brought a picture of her boss and declared her freedom." Transcript: "my mother, a few years ago was the first time I spent the seder with my mom in probably fifteen years… 'Yechil, you can run the seder, but I am leaving at ten…'… my mother that year was leaving her boss after 30 years… she came up with a picture of her boss and said,

‘Slavery and freedom.’” The summary generalized it to “a mother.” Also, the write-up has the picture of the boss “after thirty years of employment” as an example listed separately from the story; the transcript has them as one. *Corrected in the HTML.*

Flag 2 — “Best known for his books.” The lead describes the speaker as “best known for his books and for his website awesomepesach.com.” Neither file mentions books (the speaker mentions “150 pages of amazing Torah” and his website). *Corrected in the HTML (books removed).*

Flag 3 — “My older son Amir.” Transcript: “So I give Amir or my children, they get older. We put on this… outfit.” The summary has “my son Amir or my older children, as they grow.” Nothing says Amir is the older son. *Corrected in the HTML.*

Flag 4 — fn 14: “Amazon-affiliate” and “updated annually.” The speaker says there is a link to Amazon, “no pressure at all,” and that he is “not selling them to make two dollars but as a service”; he says he updates the site “constantly,” not annually, and nothing about an affiliate arrangement. *Corrected in the HTML.*

Flag 5 — fn 1: not the Chida; the *Imrei Chaim*. The write-up (body and fn 1) has “The ר is the א"ש in his כל פסח.” Plaud: “It’s not about a night to just simply spend time together, it’s a night of… I’m sorry? I believe that’s from the י חיים *Imrei Chaim*. Really? בסדר, thank you.” So an audience member supplied the source, and the speaker accepted it. The Sofer text has “from the Chaim really a Kol Pesach,” and the summary turned that into the Chida’s *Rosh Kol Pesach*. The note then adds *Simchas HaRegel*, a “kabbalistic underpinning” and the claim that the *seder* “draws down the spiritual flow for the whole year,” none of which is the speaker’s. Rosh Hashanah 2a (confirmed on Sefaria: 1 Nisan is the New Year for kings and the festivals) is real but is not his source. *Corrected in the HTML: body and fn 1 now give the Imrei Chaim as supplied from the floor; the Chida claim and the kabbalistic sentence removed; the work and passage UNCERTAIN.*

Flag 6 — fn 7: Shabbos 97a. The note says *Chazal* (Shabbos 97a) teach that

after the staff returned to its original form it still contained the swallowed staffs. Sefaria's Shabbos 97a has R' Elazar: "a miracle within a miracle; it was Aaron's staff, not his serpent, that swallowed the other staffs." Nothing about the staff reverting or still containing the others. *Corrected in the HTML.*

Flag 7 — fn 13: where the line is, and what "the *midrash*" recounts. The note puts *v'chol hamarbeh* "immediately following the four sons" and says "the *midrash* goes on to recount" the sages of Bnei Brak. The account of the five sages is the *haggadah* itself (confirmed on Sefaria's Story of the Five Rabbis page, where the line does not appear). *Corrected in the HTML: placement claim removed; "midrash" changed to "haggadah."*

Flag 8 — fn 2: an internal cross-reference. "see file 58 fn 10 for the four occurrences in the ה" refers to a different file in the production series, not to anything in the shiur or the document. *Removed in the HTML.*

Flag 9 — The title "ת חיים." Plaud: "says the ת אמת *Sfas Emes*, something fascinating: you paint a picture…" The Sofer text: "says the sifse chaim." The summary and the write-up have ת חיים (body, fn 11, fn 12), with the author identified as R' Chaim Friedlander; the speaker names no author. The two transcripts disagree on the title and the recording was not re-listened to, so the body was not changed. *Hedge added to fn 12 in the HTML; title, author and passage UNCERTAIN.*

Flag 9a — The inscription on the staff (Section XII). The write-up: "Write ז אהרן on the outside" (the summary), and the demonstration is of "the מטה of ן." Plaud: "I write ך עד"ש באח"ב on the outside, so it's really Moshe's stick"; Sofer: "tzachadash ba'achav." He says Moshe's stick throughout. (The verse has Aaron's rod, Exodus 7:12, confirmed.) *Corrected in the HTML.*

Flag 9b — *Hodu*, not *Shiras HaYam*. The write-up (Section XIV, fn 9, the props list): the family sings ת הים on reaching the instruments. Plaud: "we sing ו להשם כי טוב *Hodu l'Hashem ki tov*, thank you Hashem"; Sofer: "we sing 'Thank you Hashem.'" The summary supplied *Shiras HaYam*. Psalms 136:1 confirmed on Sefaria. *Corrected in the HTML, including fn 9 (the kabbalistic remark removed).*

Flag 9c — *Shelo lishmah*, not *she'eilos lishmah*. Section VIII: "שאלות לשמה — questions for their own sake." Plaud, twice: "You want to have as much שלא מה as possible… The key is א לשמה. On the night of the seder it's שלא מה. You want to offer rewards for questions more than anything." The speaker says the opposite: the rewards are not for their own sake. Sofer has "shalom l'shma," the summary "לות לשמה." *Corrected in the HTML.*

Flag 9d — Smaller corrections made in the HTML. (a) The frog was bought at עות time and hidden ten and a half months (Plaud; the body had ה from the summary, and Chanukah to Pesach is not ten and a half months). (b) The Keep Focus card reads "Hand in this card at ״ים היינו (Plaud, and Sofer "Avin Dimayinu"), not at . (c) "I bribe you *once a year*" (Plaud), not "this one time."

Flag 10 — Wine and *matzah* measures. Body: wine minimum "approximately 3.3 ounces" (the speaker's figure). Fn 4: *rov revi'is* "~75 ml / ~2.5 oz," and *matzah* at "approximately 30 g" for each of *motzi*, *korech* and *afikoman* ("one half of a hand-shmurah"). The speaker gave no figures for *matzah* or *maror* ("a list of measurements"), and says wine is "about three point three." Fn 10 then gives 75–98 ml. The note's figures contradict the body and are not from the shiur. *Not edited in the HTML (not a Sefaria matter); the Sefer Edition drops the figures.*

Flag 11 — Minor. (a) The sample question list has "What is good about having structure?"; the transcript has "What's good about having a seder?" (garbled; the summary's "structure" may be a guess). (b) "Dave & Buster's for prizes and toys" comes from the summary; the transcript says he got a prop there. (c) The summary and write-up give denominations as ones, fives, tens and twenties; the transcript has "ones, fives" and "fifty, ten, etc." (d) The write-up calls Section VII's items "prizes"; the speaker says the cards name prizes. Not edited.

4.Content Flags — Omissions

Said in the shiur and left out of the write-up. The first four are substantive.

- **The Targum.** The speaker's one *dvar Torah* opens with "the Targum actually says, not 'you should tell your child,' you should show your child," which is why the family acts things out and "the goal is not to remember but to relive." The write-up has only the grammar of והגדת לבנך in Section II (the parent tells, not the child) and no Targum; the summary lists a Targum among the sources and does not explain it.
- **The *sheloshim* anecdote.** The illustration of the Sifsei Chaim: he gave this very *dvar Torah* some 22½ years ago ("twenty-three and a half" a moment later) at the *sheloshim* of his wife's brother, who died at eighteen, a beloved student at Frisch, to about three hundred people in a gym: look at what everyone is wearing, what the walls look like. The write-up gives the principle without the story. The summary omitted it.
- **The diet example** in the same passage: he has spoken for half an hour, mentioned he is on a diet, has lost fifty pounds in a year and a half without Ozempic or exercise, and has not yet overcome it; the point is that re-experiencing a victory renews the feeling. Omitted.
- **The ADD *haggadah*.** "I personally have an ADD haggadah, a haggadah of short *divrei Torah*. But that is not the goal of the seder… not gematrias and *pshatim*; the goal is to tell over the story." The write-up has only the closing contrast in Section XVII. (The summary has it.)
- ***Chad Gadya* pictures**: everyone gets a picture of one of the characters of the song and makes its sound. Not in the summary or the write-up.
- **The snake prop:** a stick that, dropped on the floor, becomes a snake (found last year for $25–30, delivered on *Pesach* itself); he tried it on stage and it first failed. Also the TSA taking the plastic knife in Phoenix ($12 replacement, from a Five Below), the hand taped to a stick ; the hand taped to a stick is clearer in Plaud ("lifted up Moshe

and brought him back," apparently Paroh's daughter's arm); the sponge, ruler and borscht passage remains unclear.

- **Doorpost tape.** He used to place the red painter's tape on the outside; "Rabbi Willig from Woodmere pointed out it's supposed to be on the inside" (Plaud spelling). The write-up has the correction without the attribution.
- **The cost and size of props:** five inflatable animals for about $70; the 4 x 12 foot wall covering of which he brought a sample, lining two walls, with candy bags, one for each *seder*; his daughter Malka painting the reed basket black ($1 after Easter at Walmart); the lamb that "survived many governments" (T.J. Maxx; Costco); Old Navy on Central; Gourmet Glatt for salt water.
- **Shekalim details:** printed in color at Office Depot; a company called "Thank You Hashem," whose video of him rebranded them ("I took theirs"); hand them out freely; do not make the figure too crazy; "somebody told me… his kids enjoyed the seder shekalim so much they didn't want the prize." Partly in the write-up.
- **The ages of his children** (seven to twenty-four), the range he engages (four or five to the early twenties), and "my seder, hopefully, will be ten people."
- **The mannequin challenge context:** teaching high school for twenty years; the video fad about ten years earlier.
- **The close:** "The goal of the seder is not entertainment. The goal is engagement. The goal is inspiring… We're leaving our constrictions, our limitations"; the website lets people contact him, and there is a scale on it ("everything you could possibly need for the non-creative parent"); the posters are $22–25. The write-up has the sense of the ending but not these.
- **The closing line of the *haggadah*.** Plaud: ואף אתה אמור לו כהלכות הפסח אין מפטירין אחר הפסח אפיקומן, "which means the goal of the seder is that the

afikoman should stay with you forever.” The Sofer text garbles it; the summary and the write-up omit it.

- **Unclear or omitted in both:** two of his children “in Cairo right now” (Plaud has it too); “by tomorrow we’ll have three kids who actually left Egypt”; the “eclipse glasses” and the Conservative/Reform website passage on music and lights; the Baluner Rebbe who sells *bekishes*; and that it bothers him when people ask what time the *seder* ended and say an hour earlier. (“Weberman kids” is in the Sofer text only.)

5.Added or Editorial Material Not in the Shiur

Apparatus and framing supplied by the write-up; the numbers refer to the footnotes.

- **Lead:** “best known for his books” (corrected); “mid-week שיעור” (the weekday of 18 March 2026 is Wednesday, but the recording does not say the shiur was a regular mid-week one, and the Sofer text and summary end with “Shabbos Shalom,” which Plaud does not have); “reworked version” and the headline “A Practical Guide for Parents” are the writer’s.
- **Fn 1:** the Chida, the *Simchas HaRegel* reference, the “kabbalistic underpinning” (corrected; Flag 5).
- **Fn 3:** the Rambam’s reading of להראות as a positive obligation to demonstrate “which the Chida and others read”; Rambam 7:6 does read להראות (confirmed), the Talmud and the *haggadah* לראות, but the Chida claim is not from the shiur.
- **Fn 4:** the gram and milliliter figures; “Verify against contemporary halachic guides” is a working note left in the text.
- **Fn 5:** the list “dipping twice, leaning, the second cup, the breaking of the matzah” and the quotation כדי שישאלו at Pesachim 116a. Sefaria’s

Pesachim 116a confirms that dipping twice is to prompt the children to ask, but the quoted phrase was not located and the list is the writer's. The speaker's reward system as an "application" is also the writer's.

- **Fn 8:** *Shemos Rabbah* 22:1 and *Tanna DeVei Eliyahu*; the speaker says only "the *Midrash* says." The passage was not found in *Shemos Rabbah* chapter 1 on Sefaria; chapter 22 not checked.
- **Fn 9:** "draws on the kabbalistic principle that *Shiras HaYam* at the *seder* reactivates the original moment of redemption"; not from the shiur, and the song is *Hodu* (Flag 9b; corrected).
- **Fn 10:** the *Mishnah Berurah* "stresses" the preference for smaller cups. Shulchan Aruch OC 472:9 (confirmed) sets the cup at a *revi'is* and treats drinking most of a larger cup; the *Mishnah Berurah* was not checked.
- **Fn 11 and fn 12:** "many מפרשים" read the verse as a model; R' Chaim Friedlander, 1923–1986, as the author; a description of his work.
- **Section XVII:** the statement that the speaker explains the verse "in the seder" as pedagogy ("make the *seder* visceral") in fn 11 is the writer's gloss.
- **Fn 14:** "Amazon-affiliate," "updated annually" (corrected).

6.Halachic / Lomdish Observations

The obligation to see oneself. Confirmed on Sefaria: Mishnah Pesachim 10:5 (each generation must view itself as having left Egypt, citing Exodus 13:8); the Rambam's text at Chametz UMatzah 7:6 reads לראות ("present himself"), the Talmud (116b) and the common *haggadah* לראות; the speaker quotes חייב לראות את עצמו as the familiar reading. His own use is homiletic (relive, not remember); the write-up's attribution to the Chida of a halachic obligation to act it out is unsupported.

Exodus 13:8. Confirmed: "And you shall tell your son on that day" (the

Mishnah's own citation). The summary's locator, 12:26, is a different verse. The speaker's contrast (והגדת לבנך not הגד לבנך) is a homiletic reading of the verb and the pronoun, not a halachic ruling that the child may not speak.

The Targum. Sefaria's English of Onkelos on 13:8 (Metsudah) is "You must tell your son"; the Aramaic was not retrieved, so the speaker's "show" could not be checked. The point may depend on the Aramaic root of Onkelos's rendering of והגדת to be confirmed with the speaker.

Cups and quantities. Shulchan Aruch OC 472:9 (confirmed): the four cups are a *revi'is* each after mixing; a larger cup may be shared; and a dissenting view that one must drink most of the cup even when it holds several. This is not the same as the write-up's "*rov revi'is* per cup according to most *poskim*" in fn 10. The speaker's advice ("better a full cup than the majority of a bigger cup") is practical, and the 3.3 oz figure is his.

Pre-measured bags. The speaker says explicitly "I do not do this for halachic reasons." A write-up should not present the bags as a *halachic* solution; its fn 4 suggests figures for the minimum amounts, which the speaker does not.

Aaron's staff. Exodus 7:10–12 (confirmed; Aaron's rod swallowed their rods); Shabbos 97a: R' Elazar, a miracle within a miracle. The speaker calls it the staff of Moshe, writes "משה אהרן" and says "six other staffs," none of which is in the verse (the number of the magicians' rods is not given).

Mi'beis avadim. Exodus 20:2 and Deuteronomy 5:6 both read "the house of bondage" (confirmed). The 210 years and the seven weeks are the speaker's figures (the period of 210 years is the common tradition, not retrieved).

The Mishnah on the Bnei Brak account. Confirmed on Sefaria's Story of the Five Rabbis: the five sages reclined in Bnei Brak, told of the exodus all night, until their students came and said the time for the morning *Shema* had come.

7.Follow-up Questions Worth Asking the Rav

Q1.Which *Imrei Chaim* (and where) says that the whole year is in the *seder*?

Q2.Which Targum, and in what words does it say “show your child”?

Q3.Was it the *Sfas Emes* or the *Sifsei Chaim*, and where is the passage on *mibeis avadim*?

Q4.May the personal anecdotes (his wife’s brother’s *sheloshim*, his mother’s boss, the diet) be printed?

Q5.The date and occasion: what did “by tomorrow we’ll have three kids who actually left Egypt” refer to, and where was the talk given?

Q6.What did the passage about the children in Cairo say?

Q7.The sources for the *midrash* of the blood penetrating the fruit and the *midrash* of the babies as bricks.

Q8.The sponge with red borscht, the ruler and the Baluner Rebbe who sells *bekishes*: what was said? (And is the hand on a stick Paroh’s daughter’s arm?)

Q9.Does he want the *matzah* and *maror* measures printed, and by which opinion?

8.Bottom Line

A faithful write-up of a lively, practical shiur, which it organizes well. Its errors come from the summary and from the apparatus: one anecdote told about the wrong person, an unsupported lead, and a set of footnotes (1, 3, 4, 5, 7, 8, 9, 10, 12, 13, 14) and several details (the Chida, shelo lishmah, the staff inscription, Hodu) that assert more than the shiur or the sources support. With those hedged or removed, the Targum point, the sheloshim story, the ADD haggadah and the Chad Gadya pictures restored, and the Hebrew date supplied, the sefer edition can stand. The weakest points are the opening source (Imrei Chaim), the Sfas Emes/Sifsei Chaim title, the cup and matzah figures, and the midrash locators.

Produced by a content-based review pass reading the bilingual transcript, the Sofer-style transcript, the AI summary, and the finished write-up (as delivered, before the corrections described above were applied). No Sofer .docx was present for this date. The guest shiur is by Rabbi Yechiel Spero, not by Rabbi Ephrati.